



Purple patch: South Korea breezed through qualifying, going unbeaten across 16 matches and finishing six points clear of Jordan in the final group stage. GETTY IMAGES

from Group B, a path that could quickly become complicated.

Korea Republic arrives with names that command respect, even if its build-up has been accompanied by familiar questions about whether it can control matches against stronger opposition. Son Heung-min, now 33, remains its emotional and attacking reference point. Kim Min-jae brings elite-level presence to the backline, Lee Kang-in can decide matches between the lines, and Hwang Hee-chan offers intensity in transition. Hong Myung-bo's side reached the last 16 in Qatar, but its hopes here will depend on whether it can impose itself rather than merely survive phases of play.

The opener against Czechia in Guadalajara is crucial. Victory would allow Korea Republic to approach the Mexico game with freedom. Defeat would make the second match heavy with pressure.

Czechia returns to the World Cup after a 20-year absence with a side built less on flair and more on structure. Its qualification route was not smooth, but a playoff win over Denmark secured Miroslav Koubek's team a hard-earned place in North America. Patrik Schick remains the primary threat in attack, Tomas Soucek gives the midfield height and authority, and Ladislav Krejci provides

ON THE RADAR



Santiago Gimenez (Mexico)

Mexico's attack needs a finisher capable of turning home advantage into goals. Gimenez gives Aguirre movement, penalty-box instinct and the ability to press from the front. If Mexico is to top the group, it will need him to deliver more than just promise.



Son Heung-min (Korea Republic)

Son may no longer be at his physical peak, but he remains Korea Republic's most decisive footballer. His finishing, leadership and ability to exploit space make him central to its knockout ambitions, particularly in tight matches against Czechia and Mexico.